

BOLÍVAR, SIMÓN



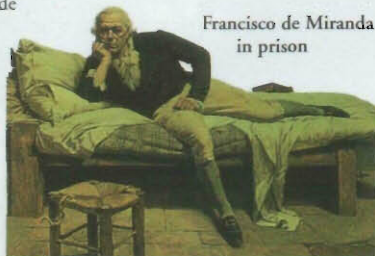
SIMÓN BOLÍVAR WAS the brilliant and charismatic leader who led South America to independence from 400 years of foreign rule. Together with other generals, he overthrew the Spanish in just 12 years. As president of the federation of Gran Colombia, he wanted to rule the whole continent, but this dream came to nothing. To this day, he is still known as "The Liberator", and one of the South American nations, Bolivia, is named after him.

Fighting for independence

At the start of the 19th century, all of South America, except Brazil and Guiana, was under the rule of the Spanish king Ferdinand VII. Many South Americans resented this and wanted to govern themselves. In response, independence movements broke out all over South America. Bolívar, keen to work in the independence movement, returned to South America and fought the Spanish in Venezuela.

First republic

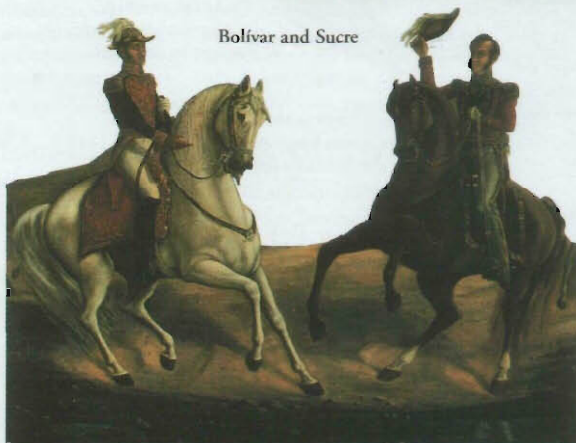
In 1810, Francisco de Miranda returned from exile in Europe and was made president of the new republic of Venezuela. In 1811, it became the first South American country to declare independence from foreign rule. Bolívar joined the rebel army, but the republic collapsed. He carried on the struggle, going to Colombia to fight the Spanish there.



Francisco de Miranda in prison



Bolívar's storms to victory at the Battle of Carabobo



Bolívar and Sucre

Ecuador and Peru

In 1822, one of Bolívar's most talented generals, Antonio José de Sucre, defeated the Spanish at Pichincha to win Ecuador's independence. Two years later, Bolívar made a deal with the Argentinian liberator José de San Martín, whose forces were active in Peru. As a result, Sucre defeated the Spanish at Ayacucho, bringing independence to Peru. As a result of Bolívar's influence, another large area of South America was liberated.



Early life

Bolívar was born into a rich family in Caracas, Venezuela, in 1783. His parents died when he was young, and he was educated by private tutors, such as Simón Rodríguez, a teacher who taught him about European ideas, such as liberty.

Bolívar in Europe

In 1799, Bolívar was sent to Madrid to live with relatives and improve his education. While in Europe, Bolívar learned of an attempt in 1806 by Francisco de Miranda to liberate Venezuela from Spanish rule. The rebellion failed, but inspired Bolívar to fight for independence.

Ferdinand VII of Spain



Angostura Congress

At a congress held at Angostura, now Ciudad Bolívar, Bolívar was elected president of Venezuela. The congress also proposed the formation of Gran Colombia, a federation that included present-day Venezuela, Colombia, Ecuador, and Panama. Between 1819 and 1822, Bolívar won a series of victories against Spain, confirming the independence of Colombia and Venezuela, and liberating Peru.

The Liberator

From 1811 onwards, Bolívar was the focus of independence movements across South America. In 1813, he defeated the Spanish and entered Caracas, where he was given the title of "The Liberator". In 1819, he put together an army of 2,500 men and marched them across the continent to Boyacá, Colombia. He won the resulting battle, and Colombia gained its independence.

Bolivia

In 1825, Bolívar dispatched Sucre to conquer Alto Perú, in west central South America, which was still under Spanish control. Once the Spanish were defeated, the newly independent country was named Bolivia in honour of the Liberator. By now, every South American state except Uruguay had won its independence.



Bolívar's statue at government buildings, La Paz, Bolivia

SIMÓN BOLÍVAR

- 1783 Born in Caracas, Venezuela.
- 1799 Sent to Europe.
- 1811 Venezuela declares its independence; Bolívar becomes a military leader.
- 1812 First republic is defeated.
- 1813 Bolívar enters Caracas as "The Liberator", but is soon defeated.
- 1819 Angostura Congress.
- 1819 Bolívar wins Battle of Boyacá to win Colombian independence.
- 1821 Bolívar wins Battle of Carabobo to win Venezuelan independence.
- 1822 Ecuador wins independence.
- 1825 Bolivia named in his honour.
- 1830 Dies of tuberculosis.

FIND OUT
MORE

CENTRAL AMERICA,
HISTORY OF

NAPOLEON
BONAPARTE

SOUTH AMERICA,
HISTORY OF

SPAIN,
HISTORY OF